Associations and stories

Our associations

Associations are the connections that form between us and a colour. We are not born with a ready-made list “violet = this”, and yet they tend to be surprisingly similar. They are mostly made of three layers, **from the body**, **from culture** and from **what we ourselves have lived through**.

From the body

Violet is **dusk**. The moment after sunset when the sky turns from orange to dark and the world softens. It is a colour of transition, and so it often gives us a feeling of something unfinished or open. At the same time it is the colour of lilac, lavender, grapes and plums, that is, the colour of **fragrant and sweet things**.

From culture

In Europe violet was long linked with power, the church and mourning. Today we often see it as the colour of **creativity, being different and femininity**. Violet is a colour that has several meanings at once and none of them denies the others. We look at this more closely in the chapter on cultures.

From what you have lived

Grandmother's lilac in the yard, a violet dress from childhood, a lavender field on holiday, a scarf from someone who is no longer here, or the violet wrapper of a chocolate handed out at festivals. These memories decide the most. **Two women can look at the same violet** and one feels joy, the other yearning.

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is really “violet” and what is your story about it. You can ask yourself now. **What does violet connect with first for me, and where do I know it from?**

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Stories

Violet has several stories that are worth untangling. They show where the colour ends and where we begin.

The colour that cost more than silver

The word “purple” comes from the Greek **porphyra**, the name of a dye made from the mucus of sea snails of the genus Murex. The dye was already being made three thousand years ago in the Phoenician cities of Tyre and Sidon. Thousands of snails were needed for one gram. Friedländer in 1908 reports that **twelve thousand snails gave at most 1.4 grams** of pure dye. According to the Greek historian Theopompus it was sold in Colophon **at the weight of silver**. **For a long time violet was one of the most expensive colours in the world**.

The dye from the snails is chemically **6,6’-dibromoindigo**, that is, indigo with two extra bromine atoms. **Kings wore a colour that is chemically related to jeans.**

Roman magistrates wore a toga with a purple border and a victor an entirely purple one. In the 4th century AD only the emperor could wear it, and so the phrase “to put on the purple” meant **to become emperor**. In Byzantium a child born to a reigning emperor was called porphyrogennetos, that is, “born in the purple”. Today this is said of people born into wealth and privilege.

Mauve and the first artificial dye

In **1856** the eighteen-year-old chemist William Henry Perkin was trying to make artificial quinine against malaria and accidentally obtained a violet dye. At first it was called aniline purple, from 1859 mauve, after the French name for the mallow. Perkin patented it and built a factory. Between 1859 and 1861 mauve became a fashion that the magazine Punch made fun of. Violet, which once cost a fortune, was suddenly **available to almost everyone**. The dyes that grew out of this discovery created a whole branch of the chemical industry.

Suffragettes and half-mourning

In Britain and Ireland the suffragettes had three colours. **Violet** (loyalty and dignity), white (purity) and green (hope). Violet then became the colour of the women's movement in other countries too. **A colour can be a poster you wear on yourself**. It is no longer only about beauty but about **whose voice it is**.

In Victorian Britain relatives wore black for the first year after a death and then violet or dark green with black trimming. Violet was the colour of so-called **half-mourning**. In Thailand widows wear violet in mourning. **Violet is grief that is already beginning to lighten**.

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